

Virtue and knowledge



A statue of Arete, goddess of virtue, amid the ruins of the library at Ephesus, Turkey.

As well as being professional advocates and orators, the sophists (see [The sophists and relativism](#)) used their debating skills as educators. They not only trained their clients in rhetoric and argument, but also in ethics, in courses similar to those offered today by lifestyle coaches (and to a similar clientele of the rich and ambitious). What they taught was *arete*, which can be translated as ‘excellence’, but carries a notion of reaching one’s full potential. The notion of *arete* played a central role in the concept of the ‘good life’, and was effectively synonymous with the Greek idea of ‘virtue’.

Socrates believed that to live a life of virtue, you have to know what *arete* is, and so reached the conclusion that virtue *is* knowledge. He argued that virtue is necessary *and* sufficient for the good life. Someone who does not know virtue cannot lead a good and happy life, and someone who knows virtue cannot lead anything other than a good and happy life. He summed this up in the apparently paradoxical statement ‘no one desires evil’ – because virtue is knowledge, one can only do wrong out of ignorance.